SECTION 2 · STORY 2

WHAT THE BLOOD WAS FOR

The Havasupai Tribe and Arizona State University · Grand Canyon, USA · 1990–2010

The Havasupai are a Native American tribe of about 650 people, living deep in the Grand Canyon. By 1990 type 2 diabetes was common in the tribe and growing, and its members wanted answers and help. That year researchers from Arizona State University (ASU) proposed a diabetes project. Tribal leaders agreed on the understanding that it was a study to help address diabetes; in exchange, ASU let tribal members attend its classes for free. The researchers collected blood from more than 200 members. The written consent form spoke more broadly, of "behavioral/medical disorders".

The samples were used in 23 papers and dissertations. Fifteen had nothing to do with diabetes; they covered schizophrenia, inbreeding and the tribe's origins. One suggested its ancestors came from Asia, while the tribe's own history says they began in the canyon. ASU's researchers say these studies belonged to the same research into the causes of the tribe's health problems: the lead researcher told the court that donors were read a script naming diabetes, schizophrenia and depression, and the part genes may play. Tribal council member Carletta Tilousi said: "people got degrees and grants, and they never asked our permission."

The lead researcher defended the work as ethical: science often advances through studies not tied to one disease. In 2010, ASU's governing board settled. It paid $700,000 to 41 tribe members, returned the samples and apologised. No court ever ruled on whether the research broke the law. The blood went home. The published papers did not.

They gave blood for a health study.
How much permission travelled with it?